

“Merti Dusun” Tradition: Village Festivities in the month of Safar

As a village located in the slope regions of Mount Sumbing, Munggangsari doesn't only contain an abundance of natural resources, but also in culture. One of the cultures that persisted is “Merti Dusun”, a tradition that is said to be more lively than the Eid celebration. (“Merti” in Javanese means to maintain or clean, while “Dusun” means village or small town. So, “Merti Dusun” means an act of cleaning or maintaining a village or small town). “Merti Dusun” is a cultural tradition that has been passed down for generations as a way of expressing gratitude to the Almighty God for their blessing, provision, safety, and all that He has given to earth within that year. This tradition is usually celebrated on the month of Safar on the Hijriah Calendar, hence the name “Saparan” that the locals gave it. The three neighborhoods in the Munggangsari village have their own schedule for the “Merti Dusun” celebration. This year, the Kwayuhan neighborhoods celebrate it on 19 July 2026, followed by Munggangsari on the 20 July 2026, and finally the Derepan neighborhoods on 28 July 2026.

The Merti Dusun tradition started as a communal wisdom of the agrarian people in the Java isle, the people that for so long has a tradition of manifesting their gratitude for their harvest, safety, and continuity. This tradition is then passed down from generation to generation that became a cultural identity for their community in a lot of regions, this include Munggangsari village and the three neighborhoods within it. There hasn't been any concrete historical writing or documentation that points out when this tradition was first carried out or who was the mind behind this tradition. The absence of record regarding this tradition shows that “Merti Dusun” isn't just a one person idea, but it is born from a collective idea of a community that happens naturally as a part of their social life that upholds a variety of values like gratitude, collectiveness, and mutual cooperation. Aan Edwin Listanto (27), head of the service section in the village government stated that this tradition has been handed down through stories the ancestors tell to descendants and has been around for dozens if not hundreds of years. The fact remains that they preserve this tradition by holding it consistently every year in hope that the community not only remember the history behind it, but continue to safeguard the continuity of the history itself.

In general, “Merti Dusun” isn't only celebrated in Munggangsari village. This tradition is also known and commemorated in other parts of Java even without the same

moniker. It also goes by the name “Sedekah Bumi”, “Bersih Desa”, or “Saparan”; with each region having its own name and ways of honoring their tradition. In spite of it, the essence and value is still the same, which is a way to express gratitude, to pray for safety, and a way to strengthen the bond between the members. The people of Munggangsari village itself frequently called the “Merti Dusun” tradition “Saparan” because of the way it is commemorated in the month of Safar from the Hijriah calendar.

As years pass, the method of upholding the tradition has gone through change and adaptation to follow the community's growth. In spite of it, the value of such traditions continue to persist amongst the change. Those worth being the manifestation of appreciation toward the Almighty God, a tribute to cultural heritage, and a way to maintain connection and affection toward each other. The main reason for the existence of such tradition is as a form of their thankfulness for all the grace that has been given, be that in health, wealth, safety, abundance, or peace within the last year. Nevertheless, if we take a step back, “Merti Dusun” doesn't just contain a spiritual dimension, but also a strong social culture dimension. This tradition became a momentum for the society as a whole to gather, maintain social connection, strengthen ties, and deepen mutual cooperation. In the cultural dimension, this tradition transforms into a way for the people to preserve their local tradition through various activities such as “pewayangan” (the equivalent of puppet show). Taking it further, “Merti Dusun” also gave a benefit in the economic dimension as it gave room for small businesses to sell their wares in this festival.



Image 1. The Atmosphere of Merti Dusun in Derepan Neighborhood with Merchant on the side road



Image 2. The Atmosphere of Merti Dusun in Derepan Neighborhood with Merchant on the side road

The election for the month of “Merti Dusun”, that is the month of Safar, is not only a matter of choice, but a part of tradition for the people. Up until now, the choosing of date is kept as a form of respect to the tradition and cultural heritage of the ancestors. Usually when it comes to choosing the right time, there will be a discussion between the neighborhood or village government and public figures, elders, committee, and other important people in the village. This process ensures that the tradition is held successfully, actively involving the community, and ensures the schedule doesn't clash with other neighboring events.

In celebration of the “Merti Dusun”, the Derepan neighborhoods start off in the morning by “selamatan” with the whole village. (Selamatan is an Indonesian tradition where a community gathers to pray together as a way of expressing their gratefulness to the Almighty God, usually followed by eating together provided by a public figure or cooked together). In the first series of events, the community will bring all sorts of traditional food like rice, tapai, sticky rice or juadah, banana, and chicken filling that is pierced with small bamboo.



Image 3. Dish served at “Selametan Merti Dusun” (filling, tapai, juadah, rice, banana, and coffee)



Image 4. Dish served at “Selametan Merti Dusun”

This event is done as a place to pray together in symbol of their gratitude for the wealth, health, abundance, and safety that has been given to them. After praying together, they will feast on the food that has been brought as a form of comradery and fraternity.



Image 5. Potrait of inhabitant alongside the serving when Selamatan Merti Dusun at Dusun Derepan



Image 6. Potrait Inhabitant at the “Selamatan” Merti Dusun at Dusun Derepan

At noon, there will be “pagelaran wayang kulit” or a shadow puppet show that is a point of interest in the “Merti Dusun” event. At the same time, the public use this moment to visit one another to meet and greet each other, or “silaturahmi”. This “silatutahmi” is not only done by the community and their family, but also by the community from other neighborhoods. In a sense, Merti Dusun became a place for social interaction that deepened the bond of the community. Lastly when night falls, the shadow puppet show will begin again through the night until dawn, or until the end of the story.



Image 7. Potrait “Pagelaran Wayang” or Shadow Puppet Play at Merti Dusun at Derepan neighborhood

“Merti Dusun” is an event that involves all elements of the community without looking at their age, profession, or social backgrounds. Children, teenagers, adults, or even elders all participate in accordance with their own roles. This tradition also involves village officials, elders, youth groups, and volunteers that together work to succeed this event. This tells us that the event is the result of collective work and not depending on only a few people. Apart from the villagers from the village that celebrate the “Merti Dusun”, other villagers from nearby neighborhoods are also involved and visit to meet and greet each other while also watching the spectacle of the event. The execution of “Merti Dusun” is not an internal activity of one neighborhood, but an open festival that gives space to strengthen the social bond with people from other neighborhoods or villages.



Image 8. Potrait “Silaturahmi” in “Merti Dusun”

The “Merti Dusun” tradition is not only in Munggangsari village, but also in other villages, particularly one in the middle Java or the regions of Magelang. However, each village has their own moniker and methods to celebrate this tradition. Some regions conduct “kirab budaya”, “gunungan hasil bumi”, cultural art performance, or certain cultural rituals. As written before, in the Munggangsari village, they have their own characteristics, which is selamatan in the morning, shadow puppet show from noon to night, and a meet and greet in between.

This event is dynamic and easily adaptable following the era. However it is noted that they continue to uphold their main values that are passed down by their ancestors. The main identity of “Merti Dusun” lies in the combination of spiritual activities, social, and tradition in one event. With Selamatan being the spiritual dimension part, the “silaturahmi” being the social part, while the shadow puppet show being the cultural dimension from the “Merti Dusun” tradition in Munggangsari village.



Image 9. Potrait hustle of Merti Dusun in Dusun Derepan

Some people say that the “Merti Dusun” tradition is more festive and lively than the celebration of Eid, however these two events have different characteristics that separate them. If the Eid is focused on the spiritual and silaturahmi momentum within the family, “Merti Dusun” becomes a momentum that connects all parts of society in one series of events from the tradition, social, and spiritual dimension. In “Merti Dusun”, people don't only meet and greet, but also gather to pray together and watch the shadow puppet together. While “Merti Dusun” might be more festive, that doesn't mean it is more important than the Eid celebration, since the two of them have different meanings. The Eid is a religious holiday that maintain the spirit of worship, while the “Merti Dusun” is a cultural tradition that became a place to deepen social bond and preserve cultural heritage. Because of this reason, the “Merti Dusun” atmosphere is more often than not much more lively than that of Eid celebration. As part of the tradition and life of the people in Munggangsari village, the people strive to continue the “Merti Dusun” tradition on any condition. This tradition has been passed down from generation to generation and has a deep meaning to the community thus there is a communal commitment to continue to preserve and hold this tradition.



Image 10. Potrait of inhabitant watching the Shadow Puppet

As a tradition that has rooted itself strongly in the people's lives, “Merti Dusun” is in need of continual documentation as a form of identity and characteristics of the Munggangsari village. Eventhough similar tradition can be found in a few regions, however the festivities atmosphere of “Merti Dusun” in Munggangsari village became its own point of interest that is worthy of promotion. In the preservation aspect, Munggangsari village has proven to be able to maintain and continue this tradition. The next strategic path would be to manage this tradition so it became a plus point for the village, for example through the development of cultural excursion destinations. Through introduction of value, meaning, method, and festivity of this tradition to the general populace, “Merti Dusun” will not only continue to be preserved, but give an economic impact to the people from business opportunity.